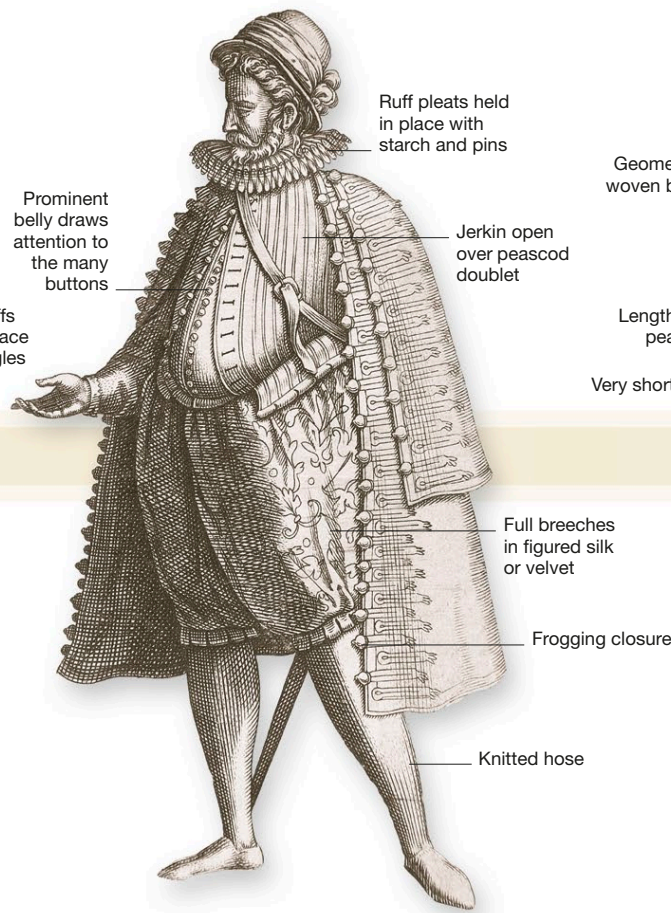




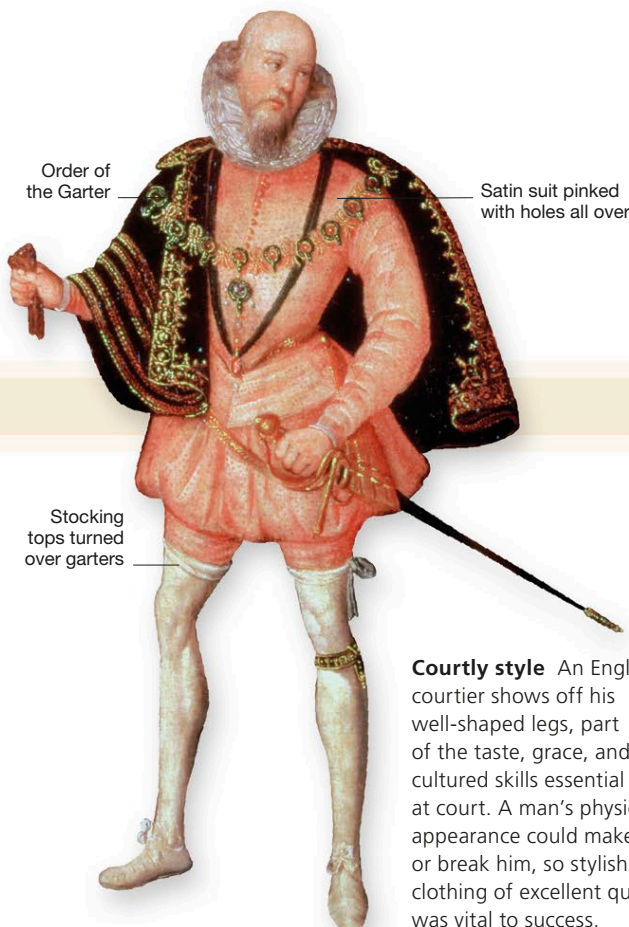
Dark majesty King Henri III of France wears the garb of the Order of the Holy Spirit, which he started in 1578. The blue ribbons used to hold the Order's medallion may be the origin of the phrase "cordon bleu" for excellence.



Eastern influences This Frenchman wears longer upper breeches, called Venetians, in patterned fabric. The frogging closures on his robe follow Eastern fashions, sometimes referred to as Polish style in Western Europe.



Youthful beauty A fashionable young Englishman displays his elegant legs under very short paned breeches. The artful draping of his sleeved cloak over one shoulder and his careful posture suggest a studied poetic melancholy.



Courtly style An English courtier shows off his well-shaped legs, part of the taste, grace, and cultured skills essential at court. A man's physical appearance could make or break him, so stylish clothing of excellent quality was vital to success.

TAILORING

In this period, cut, as much as fabric and decoration, became a mark of taste. Skilful tailoring did much to improve the wearer's appearance through fit. Stiffening and padding – a harder shell around a soft core – made the clothed body very different from the natural one. Different materials helped to create rigidity: linen, buckram (stiffened linen cloth), cardboard, and parchment, and various weaves of wool. Stuffing with bran, horsehair, or unspun fleece created large, unnatural shapes.

Pattern books from the 1580s onwards reveal the tricks of subtle cutting and economical fabric use. Basic tailors' tools from the period are still used today: measuring stick, chalk, pins, and shears (right).



Juan de Alcega's pattern book

Spanish pattern from 1580s



Late 1560s Italian portrait of a tailor